

Remote Interpretation Setup Checklist

Everything you need for legally defensible remote interpretation via OPI, VRI, and virtual platforms

- ✓ Pre-session technology checklist (14 items)
- ✓ Platform comparison: OPI vs VRI vs virtual courtroom
- ✓ ADA and DOJ compliance requirements for remote interpretation
- ✓ Troubleshooting quick reference for common issues

Pre-Session Technology Checklist

Attorney / Participant Equipment

- ☐ HD webcam with clear facial visibility (for VRI — interpreter must see speaker's face and gestures)
- ☐ Noise-canceling headset with microphone (NOT laptop speakers/mic)
- ☐ Hard-wired Ethernet connection (NOT Wi-Fi)
- ☐ Minimum 10 Mbps download / 5 Mbps upload (VRI requires higher bandwidth than audio-only)
- ☐ Quiet, private room with minimal background noise
- ☐ All documents that may need sight translation pre-sent to interpreter (PDF format)
- ☐ Phone dial-in number for audio backup
- ☐ Secondary device charged and ready as backup

Interpreter Equipment

- ☐ Professional-grade USB condenser microphone or broadcast headset
- ☐ HD webcam positioned at eye level (VRI requires full face visibility)
- ☐ Hardwired Ethernet with minimum 10 Mbps up/down
- ☐ Secondary internet connection ready (mobile hotspot)
- ☐ Glossary of case-specific terminology prepared and accessible
- ☐ Simultaneous interpretation software configured (if applicable — Interprefy, KUDO, Zoom Interpreter)
- ☐ Backup phone line for audio-only fallback

Pre-Session Protocol

- ☐ Full technical test with interpreter and all key participants 24-48 hours before

- ☐ Interpreter briefed on case subject matter, key terminology, and names/places
- ☐ All documents for potential sight translation shared with interpreter in advance
- ☐ Interpretation mode confirmed (consecutive, simultaneous, or both)
- ☐ If simultaneous: second interpreter confirmed for sessions exceeding 30-45 minutes
- ☐ All participants log in 15-20 minutes early for final testing
- ☐ Backup phone dial-in number distributed to all parties
- ☐ On-the-record stipulation drafted covering remote interpretation protocol

Critical

For VRI, the DOJ requires "real-time, full-motion video and audio" with a "sharply delineated image" of the individual and the interpreter. Laggy, pixelated, or choppy video does NOT meet ADA requirements and could be challenged.

Platform Comparison

Factor	OPI (Phone)	VRI (Video Remote)	Virtual Courtroom Platform	In-Person
Cost	\$1.50-\$4.50/min	\$2.00-\$5.00/min or hourly	Included in platform fee	Interpreter rate + travel
Setup time	Instant (on-demand)	5-10 minutes	Scheduled in advance	Interpreter must be present
Visual cues available	None	Full face, hands, gestures	Full face, hands, gestures	Full body language
Suitable for ASL	No	Yes (with proper camera setup)	Yes	Yes (preferred)
Suitable for simultaneous	Limited	Yes (with platform support)	Yes (dedicated channel)	Yes (gold standard)
ADA compliance (VRI standards)	Not applicable	Must meet DOJ technical requirements	Platform-dependent	Standard
Best for	Brief calls, scheduling, intake	Depositions, hearings, client meetings	Court proceedings	Trials, complex depositions

Major Remote Interpretation Platforms

- **Zoom Interpretation** — Built-in interpreter channel; interpreter assigned as "Interpreter" role; attendees select language channel. Free with Zoom license. Most widely used for legal depositions.
- **Interprefy** — Dedicated simultaneous interpretation platform; supports 200+ language combinations; AI-assisted glossary management. Used by federal agencies and international organizations.
- **KUDO** — Browser-based simultaneous interpretation; no app install required; up to 12 language channels. Growing adoption in legal proceedings.
- **Webex Simultaneous Interpretation** — Cisco's built-in interpretation feature; enterprise-grade encryption; up to 110 languages. Common in corporate legal departments.
- **Microsoft Teams Interpretation** — Language interpretation role assignment; up to 16 language pairs per meeting. Increasingly used in government proceedings.

Most virtual courtroom platforms (Zoom for Government, Webex for Courts) include built-in interpretation channels at no extra cost. Ask the court clerk which platform is in use and whether it supports dedicated interpreter audio channels.

OPI vs VRI vs In-Person Decision Guide

Which Interpretation Mode for Which Situation?

Decision matrix

Situation	Recommended Mode	Why
Emergency motion / brief hearing (< 30 min)	OPI	Fastest setup; no visual cues needed for short exchanges
Deposition (consecutive interpretation)	VRI or In-Person	Interpreter needs to see witness facial expressions and gestures
Trial testimony (simultaneous required)	In-Person (preferred) or VRI	Highest accuracy requirements; courtroom AV often insufficient for VRI
Client intake interview	OPI or VRI	Low stakes; cost efficiency matters
ASL interpretation	In-Person or VRI	Visual language — OPI impossible
Rare language (interpreter not locally available)	VRI	Only option when no local interpreter exists
Multi-language proceeding (3+ languages)	In-Person with equipment	Simultaneous interpretation booth setup; remote adds latency risk
Immigration hearing (EOIR)	VRI (standard practice)	EOIR routinely uses VRI; interpreters often remote

When to ALWAYS Use In-Person

(1) Jury trials with simultaneous interpretation, (2) Proceedings involving deaf/HOH parties who prefer in-person ASL, (3) Any setting where courtroom AV cannot support reliable video streaming, (4) Multi-day trials where interpretation fatigue is a concern.

ADA and Compliance Requirements

Legal Requirements for Remote Interpretation

ADA / DOJ Requirements for VRI

When VRI is used as an auxiliary aid, it must meet ALL of the following:

- ☐ Real-time, full-motion video and audio over a dedicated high-speed internet connection
- ☐ High-quality video images that are not choppy, blurry, or grainy
- ☐ Video sharply delineated showing the individual's and interpreter's face, arms, hands, and fingers (critical for ASL)
- ☐ Clear, audible transmission of voices
- ☐ Adequate staff training to ensure quick setup and proper operation

Failure to meet ANY of these DOJ requirements means VRI is NOT an appropriate auxiliary aid under the ADA. The organization must provide an in-person interpreter instead.

Court Interpreters Act

- Federal courts MUST provide certified interpreters for proceedings involving non-English-speaking parties
- The presiding judicial officer determines whether an interpreter is qualified
- Applies to civil and criminal proceedings, including grand jury

State Compliance Variations

- **California (Evidence Code Section 755-755.5):** Courts must provide qualified interpreters in all proceedings. Interpreter must take oath to make true and complete interpretation.
- **New York:** Interpreter must be sworn in before interpreting. Court responsible for providing interpreter services.
- **Texas:** Licensed court interpreters required. Certification by Judicial Branch Certification Commission.

Documenting Remote Interpretation

Go on the record at the start of every remotely-interpreted session to state: (1) interpreter's name and credentials, (2) language pair and dialect, (3) interpretation mode (consecutive/simultaneous), (4) all participants and their locations, (5) stipulation that all parties consent to remote interpretation format.

Troubleshooting Quick Reference

Two-column layout: Problem -> Solution

Problem	Solution
Audio echo or feedback	Use headset (not speakers). Ensure only one audio input active. Mute all non-speaking participants.
Interpreter audio drops	Switch to phone dial-in as backup. Have interpreter call in on mobile while maintaining video for visual cues.
Video freezes / pixelates	Close all other applications. Reduce video quality to 720p. Switch to hardwired Ethernet. If persistent, fall back to OPI.
Interpretation lag (> 3 seconds)	Reduce video quality. Close background applications. If platform issue, switch to backup platform.
Interpreter fatigue (simultaneous mode)	Swap to second interpreter every 20-30 minutes. Simultaneous interpretation is physically exhausting — never expect a single interpreter to sustain it beyond 30-45 minutes.
Dialect mismatch discovered mid-session	Stop proceeding. Request interpreter confirm dialect competency. If mismatch confirmed, reschedule with correct dialect interpreter. Note on record.
Party claims interpretation is inaccurate	Go on record. Ask interpreter to re-interpret the disputed passage. If challenge persists, request a certified review interpreter to assess accuracy.
Platform crashes	Reporter/court maintains record of interruption. Reconvene on backup platform. Go on record noting interruption and any testimony that may need re-interpretation.
ASL interpreter not visible on screen	Reposition camera. Interpreter must be visible from waist up with arms, hands, and face fully in frame. Use gallery view, not speaker view.
Simultaneous interpretation channel not working	Switch to consecutive interpretation as fallback. Have interpreter relay on main audio channel while tech issue is resolved.

Cost Comparison: Remote vs. In-Person

Side-by-side comparison

Component	In-Person	VRI	OPI
Interpreter fee (half-day)	\$400	\$350	N/A
Interpreter fee (per-minute, 4 hrs)	N/A	N/A	\$720 (\$3/min x 240 min)
Travel time / mileage	\$100	\$0	\$0
Parking	\$35	\$0	\$0
Equipment rental (simultaneous, if needed)	\$400	\$0	\$0
Platform fee	\$0	\$0-\$50	\$0
Total	\$935	\$350-\$400	\$720

Remote interpretation saves **50-60%** vs. in-person when travel and equipment are involved. VRI is the sweet spot for depositions — it preserves visual cues at a fraction of in-person cost. OPI is most cost-effective only for sessions under 90 minutes.

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1. ****Printability matters.**** Attorneys print these. Avoid large solid color areas on interior pages (waste ink). Reserve full-bleed backgrounds for cover and back cover only. 2. ****Tables are the star.**** These guides live or die on their reference tables. Make tables scannable, well-spaced, and easy to read at 100% zoom on screen AND when printed on letter paper. 3. ****Checklist pages should be func**

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